What Does Each of Us Believe About Medicaid?

A guide to the family conversation about Mom's situation: what each person knows, what each has heard, and how to write it down.

Your brother says Mom would never qualify. Your sister says the house wouldn't count. You're not sure where either of them heard it, and Mom may have her own idea.

This guide is for one conversation with one job: get what each person knows and believes onto one page, with the differences left on it. It isn't for deciding anything, and nobody needs to turn out to be right.

Who should be there

Mom, first. It's her situation, and she decides who else is in the room and how much she'd like to share. Then the people who would be involved if she ever needed care: the brother with the firm opinion, the sister who helps with her paperwork, the one who lives far away and can join by phone.

Pick one person to take notes. It shouldn't be the person leading the conversation.

How to open

Start with why you're talking, and say plainly that nothing is wrong.

- “Mom, you're doing fine, and nobody is suggesting that anything change. We've each heard different things about Medicaid and long-term care, and we'd like to stop guessing.”
- “We're not deciding anything today. We just want to write down what each of us knows and what each of us has heard.”
- Say what the conversation is for: one written list. Say what it isn't for: settling who is right, or changing anything about Mom's money or her house.

Questions to ask

Ask Mom

1. What have you heard about Medicaid and long-term care, and what do you make of it?

2. What would you like us to know about your situation, and what would you rather keep to yourself?

3. Is there anything about the house, your accounts or your insurance that you've wondered about?

Ask each other

1. What do you believe about Medicaid and Mom, and where did you hear it?

2. What do you know about what she has (cash, investments, a retirement account, insurance, the house, other property), and have you seen it on paper, or is it something you remember?

3. Where does what you've heard differ from what someone else here has heard?

4. What would each of us want to ask a professional?

How to write down what was said

Keep what someone has seen on paper apart from what they've heard or believe. Where two people believe different things, write both and don't settle it. Each difference goes in the last column as a question.

WHAT WAS SAID	WHO SAID IT	SEEN ON PAPER, OR HEARD?	THE QUESTION IT LEAVES
“She'd never qualify. She has too much.”	David	Heard it from a coworker	How would Mom's state look at what she has?
“The house wouldn't count.”	Denise	Read it somewhere; doesn't remember where	How might the house be treated in Mom's state?
“The house is in my name, and the deed is at the bank.”	Mom	On paper, in her safe-deposit box	

What not to decide yet

These depend on the rules in Mom's state and on details a professional will want to see. Your notes are what make that conversation useful. Leave them open.

- Whether Mom would or wouldn't qualify.
- Which of her things would count and which wouldn't.
- Whether anything should be given away, moved or put in someone else's name.
- Who heard it right.

What you can decide today

- Who will type up the list and send it to everyone, Mom first.
- Who will look for the papers that would turn “heard” into “seen.”
- Who will take each question to a professional, when the family is ready.

- Whether you'd like to talk again, and when.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't resolve a disagreement, tell you which belief is correct, or say what a professional will tell you. It gets your family to one page, with the differences left on it. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

Your family has one list now, in place of three opinions: what you know, what you believe and what you'd ask. The planning interview takes it from there: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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